

Consent Form

School of Computing and Information Systems

Technology Innovation Project



Student Researchers: Anita Yang, Tammy Lee, Bella Chen, Leo Lin

Name of Participant: Jacklyn

1. I consent to participate in this project, the details of which have been explained to me, and I have been provided with a written plain language statement to keep.
2. I understand that the purpose of this research is to investigate how individuals seek and provide local help within their communities, and to evaluate the potential of a digital platform to improve accessibility, trust, and efficiency in connecting people with local support services.
3. I understand that my participation in this project is for research purposes only.
4. I acknowledge that the possible effects of participating in this research project have been explained to my satisfaction.
5. In this project I will be required to participate in a short interview or survey about my experiences with seeking or offering local help, and I may be asked to provide feedback on a prototype or concept of a digital platform.
6. I understand that my interviews may be audio recorded.
7. I understand that my participation is voluntary and that I am free to withdraw from this project anytime without explanation or prejudice and to withdraw any unprocessed data that I have provided.
8. I have been informed that the confidentiality of the information I provide will be safeguarded subject to any legal requirements; my data will be password protected and accessible only by the named researchers.
9. I understand that given the small number of participants involved in the study, it may not be possible to guarantee my anonymity.
10. I understand that after I sign and return this consent form, it will be retained by the student researchers.

Participant Signature: Jacklyn **Date:** 30/03/2026

Interview Guide — Australia Hero

Estimated duration: 20–30 minutes **Format:** Semi-structured (follow up naturally on interesting answers)

Opening Script (read aloud)

"Hi, thanks for taking the time to speak with us today. We're a group of postgraduate students from the University of Melbourne working on a project called Australia Hero — a hyper-local platform that helps community members and students exchange small tasks and resources nearby. Before we start, you'll have received our Plain Language Statement explaining the project. Do you have any questions about it? [Pause] Great. I'd also like to ask your permission to audio record this conversation so we can review it later — is that okay? [Pause for consent form signing] Let's begin."

Section 1 — Background (3–4 min)

Goal: understand who the person is and their living context.

1. Can you tell me a bit about yourself — what you're studying or doing, and how long you've been living in your current area?
 2. How would you describe your relationship with your neighbours or the people around you?
-

Section 2 — Current Behaviours (5–7 min)

Goal: uncover real, recent experiences — not hypotheticals.

3. Think about the last time you needed help with something small — maybe borrowing something, moving a piece of furniture, or running an errand. What did you do?
 - *Follow up: Why did you choose that approach? Did it work out?*
4. Have you ever had a moment where you needed help but didn't know who to ask, or felt uncomfortable asking? Can you walk me through that situation?
5. Have you ever helped someone nearby — a neighbour, classmate, or stranger? What was that like?
 - *Follow-up: What motivated you to help? Would you do it again?*

Section 3 — Challenges & Pain Points (5 min)

Goal: validate and deepen the problem.

6. When you try to find help — whether through apps, social media, or friends — what's the most frustrating part of that process?
 7. Have you ever used a platform like Facebook groups, Nextdoor, or WhatsApp groups to ask for or offer help? What worked well, and what didn't?
 8. As an international student or someone new to the area, have you ever felt you lacked a local support network for small everyday things? Can you give an example?
-

Section 4 — Reactions to the Platform Idea (5–7 min)

Goal: gauge genuine interest and surface concerns.

[Brief explanation: "Our platform lets you post small help requests on a map — like borrowing a tool or asking for help moving a box — and nearby people can respond. There's also a reputation and reward system to build trust."]

9. What's your initial reaction to this idea?
 10. Can you imagine a situation in your own life where you'd actually use something like this? What would that look like?
 11. What would make you hesitant to use it — or stop using it after trying it once?
 - *Follow up: What would need to be true for you to feel safe interacting with a stranger through this platform?*
-

Section 5 — Trust, Safety & Incentives (5 min)

Goal: understand what builds confidence and motivates participation.

12. What would make you trust someone enough to accept help from them or offer help to them on this platform?
13. If there were a points or reputation system — where you earned recognition for helping — would that motivate you, or would it feel artificial? Why?
14. Would you prefer to remain somewhat anonymous on this platform, or would you want your real identity visible? What's your reasoning?
15. When receiving help or offering help, do you have any personal preferences regarding the helper or requester (e.g., gender, age, or other factors)?

- *Follow up:* Do you feel more comfortable interacting with someone of a particular gender in certain situations? (describe the situation)
16. Does this preference also apply when you are the one offering help to others?
-

Section 6 — Feature Priorities (3 min)

Goal: prioritise MVP features based on real user input.

17. If you could only have two or three features on this platform when it first launched, what would they be and why?
18. Is there anything you've seen in another app — not necessarily in this space — that you think would work really well here?
-

Closing (1–2 min)

19. Is there anything else about this kind of platform — or your own experiences with getting or giving help — that you think we should know?

"Thank you so much for your time. Your answers are really valuable to us. Just as a reminder, your responses will be kept confidential, referred to by a pseudonym in any reporting, and you can withdraw at any time. We'll be in touch if we have any follow-up questions."

Tips for Your Team

Before the interview: Have the Consent Form and Plain Language Statement ready. Let the participant read the PLS first, then sign the consent form before recording begins.

During: Don't rush past good stories — if someone gives a rich example, ask "can you tell me more about that?" The best insights come from specifics, not generalities.

Divide and conquer: One person asks questions, another takes notes. Rotate roles across interviews.

Target participants: Prioritise international students for interviews, as your proposal identifies them as the primary user group with the most acute pain points.

Participant Profile: Jacklyn

Q1

Demographics & Background

- **Education:** Recently graduated with Master of Mathematics degree
- **Employment status:** Currently looking for a job
- **International status:** International student
- **Length of residence in Australia:** Approximately 3.5 years
- **Current location:** Carlton, Melbourne

Residential History

- **Previous locations:** North Melbourne, South Melbourne, Deer Park, Calton
- **Frequency of moves:** Moved frequently during 3.5-year period
- **Current living situation:** Lives with 5 housemates (6 people total in household)

Q2

Social & Community Context

- **Neighbor relationships:** Reports limited interaction with neighbors in apartment setting; believes apartment living reduces spontaneous interaction ("everyone just cross their door until they go home")
- **Housemate interactions:** High frequency of interaction with housemates, particularly during shared meals in kitchen/dining areas
- **Social support network:** Primarily relies on existing friends rather than local community or neighbors
- **Local community knowledge:** Limited awareness of formal local support networks or community organizations

Q3

Key Findings from User Interview

Help-Seeking Behaviors

- **Recent experiences:** Primary example is moving—has moved multiple times during 3.5 years in Australia
- **Approach:** Initially moved without assistance; later asked friends for help with furniture transport
- **Motivation for current approach:** Friends have access to trucks/transport, making larger moves easier; also cited cost savings ("saves money")

Q4

- **Comfort level asking for help:** Reports no significant hesitation in asking friends directly; views refusal as normal and acceptable ("If they can't, then they will just refuse. I don't think it's a big problem")

Q5

Help-Giving Behaviors

- **Recent examples:** Storing belongings for international student friends during temporary returns to home countries
- **Motivation:** Reciprocal friendship, perceived house capacity, and willingness to help friends ("I think this is basically my house, so I think right now it's not a big problem")
- **Constraints:** Acknowledged that household space is limited with 6 people; would only store items if quantity is manageable
- **Willingness to repeat:** Yes, willing to help again under similar circumstances

Q6

Current Pain Points in Help-Seeking

- **Waiting time:** Uncertainty about response speed and reliability
- **Reliability concerns:** Non-friends can "just disappear" and cancel without explanation ("because they are not your friend so they can just disappear you don't know")

- **Scheduling rigidity:** Difficulty canceling or rescheduling time commitments once set for help-related tasks
- **Network limitations:** Current approach depends on having friends available; lacks local support for urgent/immediate needs

Q7

No

Q8

Don't really familiar with the local community

Q9

User Reactions & Feedback

Initial Reactions to Platform Concept

- **Overall assessment:** "I think it's a good idea for some people"
- **Key benefit:** Solves problems immediately when friend networks are unavailable
- **Specific value:** Addresses situations where friends are away ("most of their friends now they go wrong and you can't help that from your neighbors that the problem gets solved immediately which is good")

Q10

Imagined Use Cases

- **Broken appliances/utilities:** Shower/bathroom functionality issues
- **Repairs & maintenance:** Implied support for home repair problems

Movement/transport: Continued relevance for furniture moving (existing pain point)

Q11, Q12

User Concerns & Safety Issues

Privacy & Security Concerns

- **Location disclosure:** Concern that platform reveals home address/location to strangers
- **Unauthorized access to private spaces:** Risk of helpers gaining inappropriate access to bathrooms, bedrooms
- **Specific scenarios:** Concerns about helpers placing cameras in bathrooms or other private areas

Q14, 13

Trust Mechanisms Needed

- **Identity verification:** Must include visible identity/verification to build trust
- **Transparency requirement:** All interactions should occur through app (not side channels) to maintain oversight
- **Mutual visibility:** Both requesters and helpers should provide verified identity for symmetrical trust-building

Q15

Demographic Preferences

- **Task-dependent:** Preferences vary by type of help needed
- **Flexibility shown:** Participant indicates willingness to accept help regardless of helper's gender/age if safety mechanisms are in place
- **Safety prioritized over demographics:** When asked about gender/age preferences, participant prioritizes safety verification over demographic filtering

Q16

Same

Q17

Feature Priority Assessment

- **Top feature 1: Map markers with color coding**
 - Enables quick visual identification of nearby resources
 - Value: "very useful and clear"
 - Allows scanning environment at a glance
- **Top feature 2: Tooltips with help details**
 - Shows what kind of help available/needed
 - Allows decision-making before contact
 - Context for interaction
- **Ranked lower: Reputation/Leader board**
 - Questioned utility of recognition system
 - Noted "cold start problem": System has no value if only one or two people are using it ("If it's just one or two people, you never use that")
 - Critical mass is prerequisite for reputation system to motivate behavior

Q18

No

Q19

Expressed Hesitations

- **Critical issue: User adoption/network effects**
 - "the big problem is that there is enough people to use this"
 - Recognition of "cold start problem" — platform needs sufficient user base to be valuable
 - Artificial feel of reputation system without critical mass
- **Safety concerns addressed by:**
 - Identity verification system
 - Mandatory app-based communication
 - Visible verified identities for both parties

Overall Assessment

- **Strengths:** Friendly to use, genuinely solves community problems, reduces friction for help-seeking
- **Critical barrier:** Achieving sufficient user adoption to create functional network
- **Priority:** Safety mechanisms must be in place before scale
- **Final verdict:** "otherwise that you can make new friends from your neighborhood, which is good things... otherwise, and all step one is safety. Otherwise, I think it's very good"

Research Methodology Notes

Interview Execution Tips

- **Don't rush rich examples:** When participants provide detailed stories, ask follow-up probes like "can you tell me more about that?"
- **Prioritize specifics over generalities:** Best insights come from concrete examples, not abstract preferences
- **Team division:** Separate questioner and note-taker roles to ensure both conversation flow and accurate documentation
- **Role rotation:** Rotate questioner/note-taker roles across different interviews to provide variety and prevent fatigue

Participant Selection Strategy

- **Primary target:** International students, as they have the most acute pain points regarding local support networks
- **Rationale:** Limited existing social networks, new to local area, may lack family/established friend support systems

Ethical & Consent Considerations

- **Confidentiality protection:** Data password-protected, accessible only to named researchers
- **Anonymization limits:** Due to small participant pool, complete anonymity may not be possible
- **Withdrawal rights:** Participants may withdraw at any time without explanation
- **Data handling:** Consent forms retained by student researchers
- **Use of data:** Responses kept confidential, referred to by pseudonym in reporting

Consent Form Key Points

Research Purpose (Formal)

To investigate how individuals seek and provide local help within their communities and to evaluate the potential of a digital platform to improve accessibility, trust, and efficiency in connecting people with local support services.

Participant Obligations

- Participate in short interview or survey about help-seeking/help-giving experiences
- Provide feedback on prototype or concept of digital platform
- Consent to audio recording of interview

Participant Rights

- **Voluntary participation:** Participation is optional
- **Withdrawal:** Can withdraw at any time without explanation or prejudice
- **Data withdrawal:** Can withdraw any unprocessed data provided
- **Confidentiality:** Information kept confidential subject to legal requirements
- **Data security:** Password-protected, restricted access
- **Review:** Participants will be informed of follow-up questions if needed

Research Governance

- Conducted under School of Computing and Information Systems protocols
- Managed by named student researchers (Anita Yang, Tammy Lee, Bella Chen, Leo Lin)

Transcript

That's it. Hi, thank you for taking time to speak to us today. We are a group of postgraduate students from the University of Melbourne. We are working on a project called Helmet that is the youngest page. And it is a hyper-local platform that helps community members and students exchange the small text and the resource. Yeah, but before we start we have received your POS explaining the project, right? Did you have any question about it? No. No. Yeah, that's great. I would also like to ask your permission to audio record this conversation so we can review it later. Is that good? Yeah. Okay. So let's begin. Okay. Okay. Let me start with the like the background question. And can you tell me a bit about yourself? Are you studying now or working? And how long have you been living here? I've just graduated from Master of Mathematics and I'm looking for a job right now. And I've been in Australia for about three and a half years. Well, quite a long time. Where do you start when you leave? I live in Calton. Right now, I live in Calton. Have you ever been living in any other place? Yes, I live in North Melbourne, South Melbourne and Deer Park. That's good. How

would you describe your relationship with your neighbours? Mine ever is right now in Calton. In your experience? I feel like there's not much chance to interact with other people near around my place. I don't know because maybe I live in an apartment that everyone just cross their door until they go home. So I think I don't have that experience. Like how like you are living with now you are living with your roommate also. Yeah, I have five roommates Housemates housemate. Yes. Yeah, cool. That's good. Like have you are like are you having and Communication a lot of communication or conversation with them like yes because we share the kitchen and living room so everyone cooks for themselves then during the dinner time or lunch time people will gather in the kitchen just to cook their stuff and then yummy together okay good and let's talk about the behavior like about your like living style And think about the last time you needed help with something small like borrowing a small item or like moving a piece of furniture or running an errand. Do you ever have an experience like this? Yes, I moved a lot during these three and a half years. or to fight on and in the beginning I don't really have much stuff so I just go over and move by myself and after that I have some furniture and I will ask my friends for help and they may have a truck so it's easier for me to carry furniture or more stuff with me So, like, you usually ask friends for help, right? Yes. And the reason why you choose, like, ask your friends for help is that they can help you carrying the stuff, and, like, it's more easier to transport from one place to another, right? Yes, and also several money. Yes! Have you ever had a moment where you needed help but didn't know who to ask or feel uncomfortable about asking someone? Actually, no. Because I don't know if I really need help just ask. If they can't, then they will just refuse. I don't think it's a big problem. But this is how our platform want to help people to solve the problem. But that's cool opinion style. We have to face different users. Yes. Oh, I see. Help me. Yeah. But good. Then I should say maybe. That's fine, that's fine. How about, have you ever helped someone nearby? Oh yes, sometimes my friends, some of them are international students, so they may need to have a break, go back to their country. Then they may have a lease, or they don't want to have a lease in there. of their apartment, so they have to move out, but they don't have a place to leave their stuff. Then they will ask me to keep their stuff. Yeah, like, what motivated you to help? Is that only your friend, just give them a hand? Yes, because I think this is basically my house, so I think right now it's not a big problem. And would you do it again? Yes, but I was thinking about how many things that have. Since we have six people in our house, the space is quite not enough for us. So if it's not much, it's fine. Okay. That's good. And then the next one. Part is like about changing the pinpoints for helping others and receiving others help. Like when you try to find help, whether through the social media or app or x friend, what is the most frustrating part of that process? I think it's about waiting time and you can't for sure that when they cancel another meeting so because they are not your friend so they can just disappear you don't know and also when you move that you have to set a time of date that you can't cancel it. I have set time for that. Yes. Have you ever used a platform like Facebook marketing, Nextdoor or WhatsApp group to ask for other's help? Nextdoor is like a neighbor app. There is a chat box in that app and you can talk with your neighbor. I love these experiences. Yeah, that's okay. Our platform wants you. Great. As an international student and new resident in Melbourne, would you feel like it's sometimes like a local support for the small task in your daily life? from local friends? From the local support? I don't really know any local support here. I think the local support is like the local community. You can make friends with your members and you have a group of activities around your neighbourhood. No, I think because I just moved. I've moved in in Calton for half a year, so I don't really know that. And if I already have, I just ask my friend. Yeah. Okay. And let me introduce you our project. And this is an app called Helmet. And Helmet can keep you safe. That is why, the reason why we want to create this app. The problem we want to solve is that the first problem is that the resource waste. Like if you borrow a screwdriver and you only use once. and you put them like, you occupy the space in the house. It is the resource waste. You don't use them in the same time. And sometimes, like, for me, I'm a girl, and sometimes I need a physical help, a physical task, like moving the furniture. Like, I cannot find. the person who has more like segment that can help me move the furniture. And sometimes like I have a technical issue about my computers that like before the deadline of my assignment and my computer is broken and I can ask the help phone. If I can ask the help from my neighbors, I can solve the problem immediately. And this imaging shows how our app might look like. And if this app is based on the map, and on this map you will have multiple markers on this map. The red one might be the needs help, and the green one might be the supply. and people can post their required or their supplier supplies onto the app. Everyone can see the markers on this map. When you click on the markers, you can see the tool tip that gives you the information and contact for that person. It's about what they need and how to contact them. And in this app, we also filter by dynamic category, like the gender, like the category of the... Health. Yeah, category of health. And also we list map is based on distance, like only see the supplier and receiver marks around you. and we also have them

function called like friend system addition like if you if you continuous work on like having connection with your neighbors and you can like make friends with them and you can add like follow them like on Instagram you can follow them and if they have the require they can send you the app will send you the notification to remind you that your friends need help and you can see your friends need help and you can help help them immediately and this is how our like how our apps works the first part is acts nearby and then and then your neighbor will try to solve your question so like quickly and then we will have a reward and and reward system like if you think if you feel like the neighbour really give you help like you can give it a good comment yes and then yeah not about like about money but like the ranking system we will have a ranking system you can like if the person did well And you will have a higher score and every we can pick one like The best the best helper in your community and you will renew weekly Yeah Okay, that's like oh my like presentation about my our project and what is your initial reaction to this idea? I think it's a good idea for some people maybe that most of their friends now they go wrong and you can't help that from your neighbors that the problem gets solved immediately which is good Can you imagine a situation that you can use this app? I reckon maybe my store is broken or maybe the... The bathroom is small function and I couldn't take shower that I may can use my neighbors So I think that's yeah something may happen But it's okay And what would you hesitate to use this app like Like what any reason will make you like stop using this app I'd be mad at him. Maybe like 7 issues. Yes, especially if it's a 7 issue. Maybe you've got people to know where you live. And also if you're going to use others bathroom, single man's bathroom will be have the issue if he has a camera in his bathroom. Kind of a 7 issue. Yeah, that would be the problem I think about, but otherwise that you can make new friends from your neighborhood, which is good things. But if like I told you that we have like login systems that can help, like everyone should verify their identity, would it help? Yeah, that'd be great. At least that, I've never really had an ID identification or... There's a lot of way to do the verification to filter the potential dangers. It's a good way, but everything should go throughout the app. So if you just ask for help in person by Instagram, then the apps couldn't help you. So through the app will be the double. and insurance for your safety. And so you prefer to see someone like visible, like identity. And how about yourself? Would you prefer to show your identity on the app as well? Yeah, I don't mind. Because if you want to make sure the safety, then at the same time you should provide your ID as well. How about like after you something about The ranking system about this platform would you see would you see this like at least Leading ball will be like useless No, no, I reckon people may need help There's always have the market The first thing is that to know everyone know there's the app is exactly the application. If it's just one or two people, you never use that. that even you want to actually help, you still have to find out. This is a cold start problem. Yes, yes. And when you're receiving help or over-help, do you have any personal preference regarding the helper or requester? Like the gender, the age, or other factors? Not at all. I think it's almost done. The safety isn't insecure. I don't mind who is it. It depends on the task. It doesn't really matter about gender. Yeah, I mean, if you ask why you don't need to choose who they are. Also, if you want to provide help, it should be removed. Okay, if you could only have one or two features on this platform, what would be the most important part? That feature, the markers or the tooltips or the leading board. Not currently a good idea. Then you can briefly to know who's around you. Around you by the color, which is very useful and clear. And the second tool, you will know what kind of help they can provide. The last thing. Is there a safety issue or not? I think the most is exploration. That is the purpose you need. Is there anything you have seen in another app that you want to add in these apps? You can say no if you don't have it. No, that's okay. And the best question is, is there anything else about this kind of preference? Like, if you have any questions for me, you have any. I think the good idea of this app is to help people. And also, like... to solve the problem for people that they think by themselves that for some people worry or to ask help from others then they can solve this solution and also it's very friendly to use that but the big problem is that there is enough people to use this Otherwise, and all step one is safety. Otherwise, I think it's very good. Thank you.

